taken up fresh positions near the school building at Bomdila, but this was certainly not the case.

The official version of 48 Brigade's battle of Bomdila is suspect, simply because the timing of the pullback to Rupa is officially shown to be 4.45 p.m., almost three hours after the commander and the brigade staff actually abandoned their positions. The official version claims that Brigadier Gurbax Singh returned to Bomdila on the night of 18-19 November, but even if he did do so (CO 3 JAK Rif, Lieutenant Colonel Gurdial Singh's diary acknowledges that he did), it was in the wee hours of the morning and for a very brief while, which had no effect on subsequent events.

On the ground, Gurbax Singh's hurried departure was the last thing the few remaining troops in Bomdila needed to see, even though some eyewitnesses later claimed the brigade commander had stated that he was going to bring reinforcements. It also did not help matters to see the rest of the brigade staff follow the commander in quick succession. By mid-afternoon, unaware of the developments on the ground, IAF Dakotas arrived over Bomdila and dropped supplies at the DZ. There was no visible activity on the ground, for by then the only troops in Bomdila apart from the isolated and cut off 1 Madras were the advance party of 3 JAK Rifles, a few junior officers along with Lieutenant Colonel Bhupinder Singh, the commanding officer of 22 Mountain Regiment, and some gunners.

Around 3.30 p.m., the telephone in the erstwhile Brigade HQ rang. One of the gunners picked it up to find BGS IV Corps, Brigadier K. K. Singh, on the line from Tezpur, wanting to speak to Gurbax Singh. By then information had trickled down to Corps HQ that Bomdila and 1 Sikh LI positions were under attack. The gunner told K. K. Singh that neither Gurbax Singh nor the brigade staff was anywhere to be found and in fact nothing much was happening in Bomdila, since by then even the artillery guns had exhausted their ammunition and withdrawn. A few minutes later, the telephone rang again, and this time it was the DMO, Brigadier D. K. Palit wanting to speak to the seniormost ranking officer present.

Lieutenant Colonel Bhupinder Singh came on the line and confirmed that 1 Sikh LI had failed to hold the outer perimeter. He also said he had no idea what was happening to 1 Madras and that there seemed to be no communication with the battalion. The artillery officer also confirmed to Palit that the brigade commander had left Bomdila shortly after the Chinese had attacked the mobile column and occupied the outer defences.